

Great Products *Don't Matter* If No One Buys Them

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COMPANY OVERVIEW

JL Ryan Consulting



JL Ryan Consulting is a technical product advisory for early-stage MedTech startups. Founder Jamie Ryan brings 15+ years of hands-on product development experience to help founders build products that hold up under investor scrutiny.

20

Years of Medical Device Innovation

15+

Years at Silicon Valley IVD Company

100+

Early-Stage Products Evaluated

Recent Work



- University of Minnesota
 - Business Advisory Group
 - Holmes Center for Entrepreneurship
 - MIN-Corps
- Groove Capital
- VentureWell
 - Aspire MedTech
- MedTech Innovator
- BioTools Innovator

The 2026 MN Cup Semifinalists are:

Student

- [CASA Ai](#)
- [CognitionIQ](#)
- [Echo Learn](#)
- MaterniPress
- WarmWave
- [Merra](#)
- Operator_Lens
- AVNT
- [NociQuant](#)
- Brighten Up Cleaning
- VCD-Zero

Agenda

1

Innovation & Design Thinking

Innovation and prototyping aren't straight lines; using an iterative technique builds the best products. Is this part of your process already?

2

Customer Insights

The right product for your customers is probably not the one you sketched on a napkin. Pressure-test your assumptions to find the right solution.

3

Focus Areas & Additional Materials

Use standardized interview materials to uncover hidden pain points and create apples-to-apples response analysis.

**We fail more often because we solve the
wrong problem than because we get the
wrong solution to the right problem.**

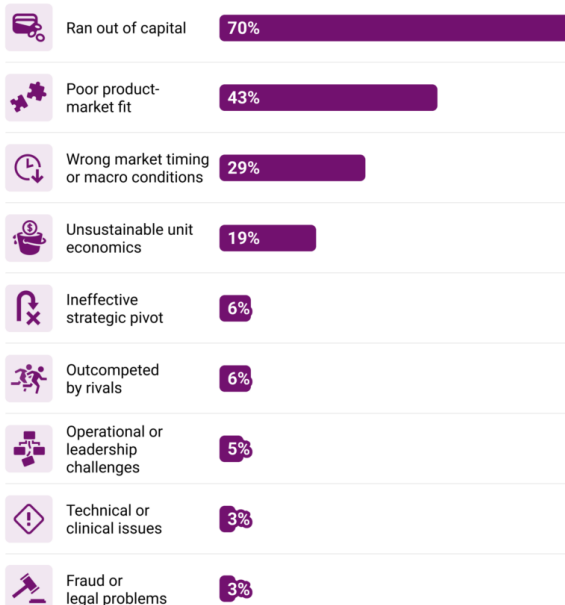
Russell L. Ackoff

Startup Shutdowns

Top 9 reasons for startup failure

CBINSIGHTS

Based on an analysis of 385 startup failures since 2023



“Two-thirds of **product-market fit (PMF) failures** were early-stage companies that never found a market.”

–CB Insights

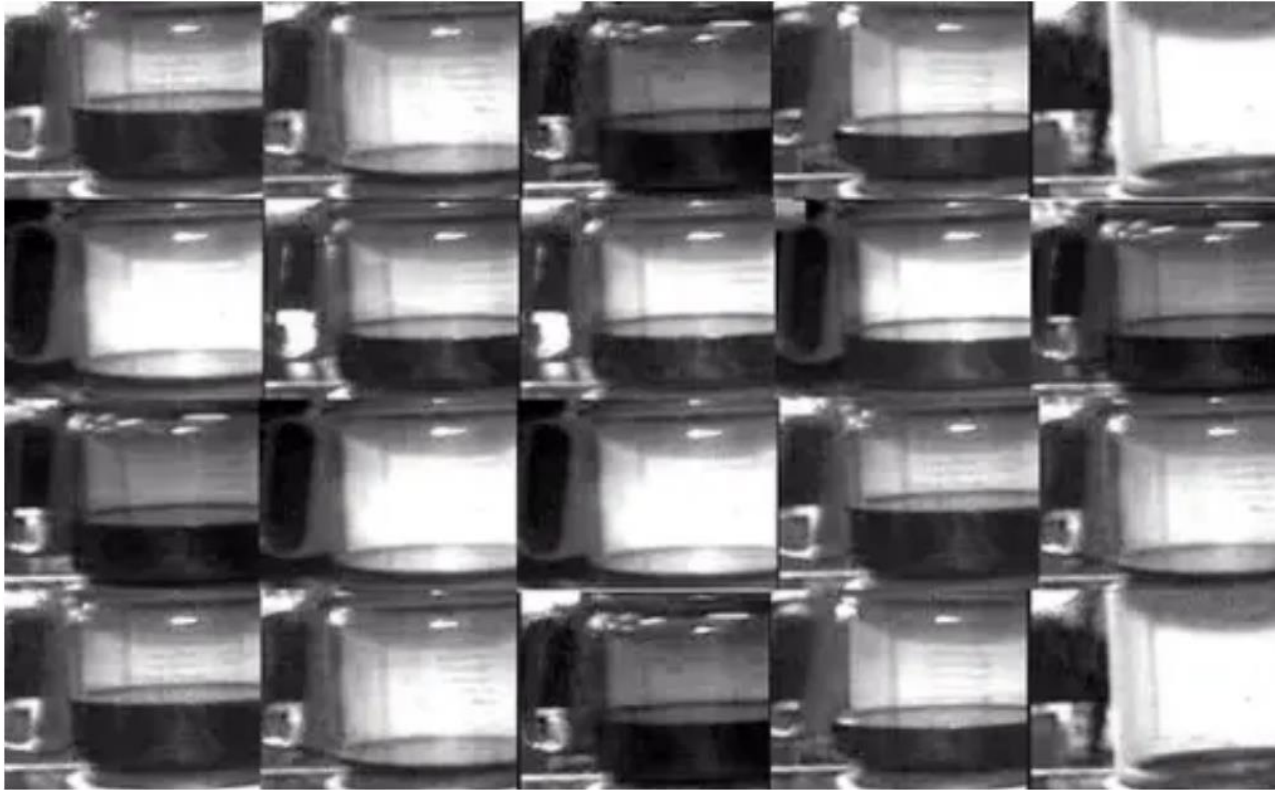
Innovation & Design Thinking

Does anyone know why the
first webcam was built?

Hint:

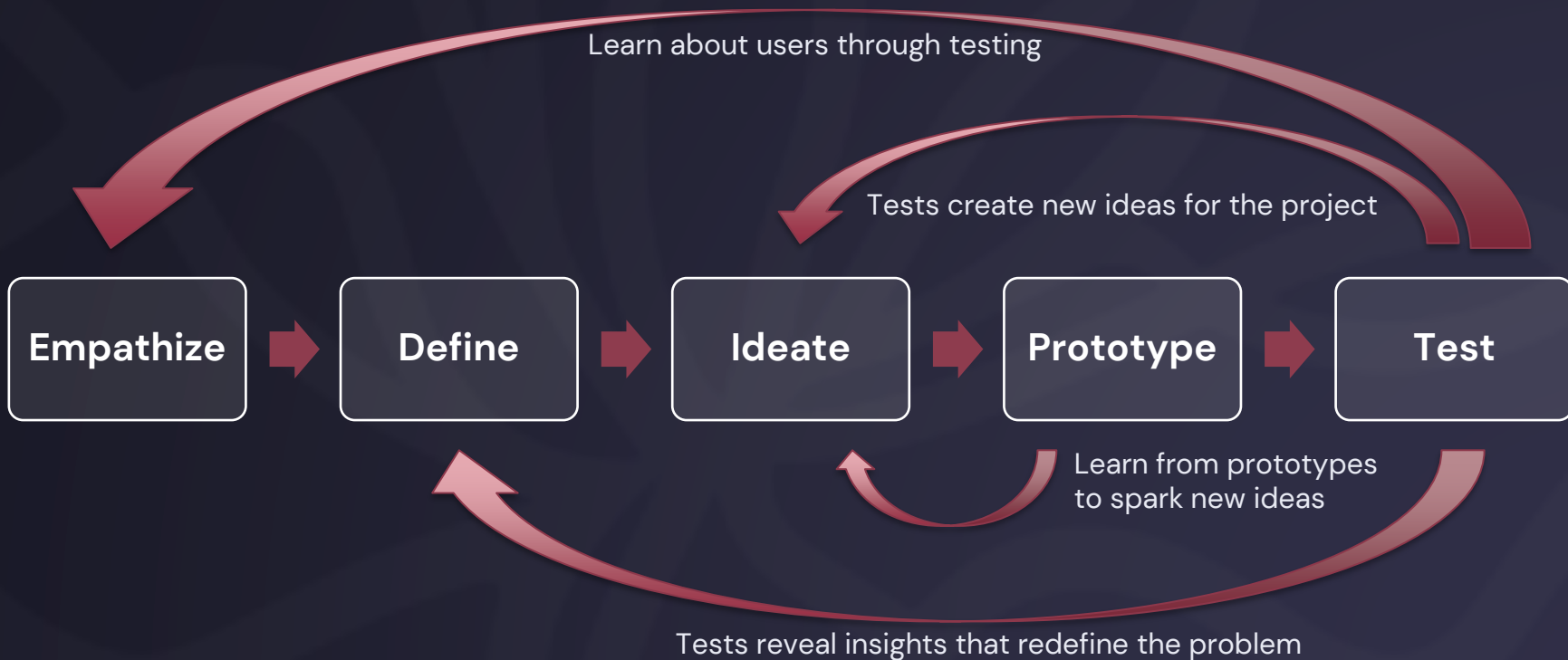
"I don't think necessity is the mother of invention—invention, in my opinion,
arises directly from idleness, *possibly also from laziness.*"

Agatha Christie



The original webcam updated the image of a coffee pot about three times a minute

How many here have heard of *Design Thinking*?



PROJECT TIMELINE....

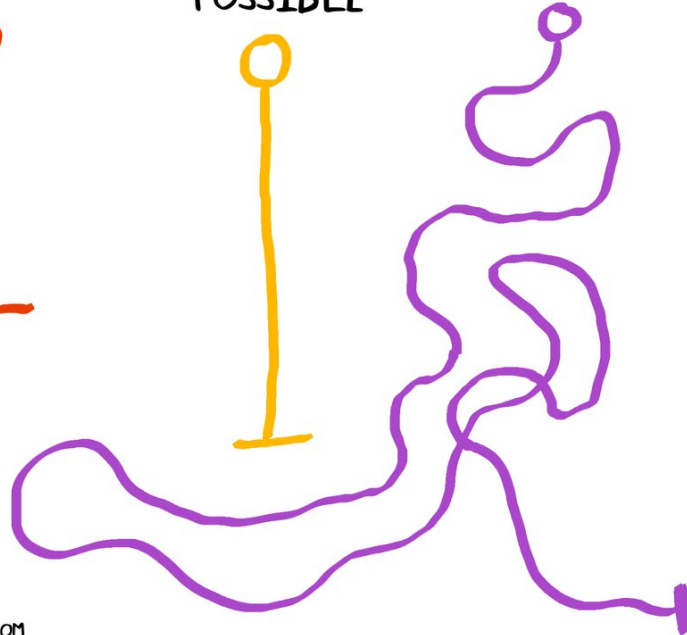
...YOUR ~~BOSS~~
EXPECTS



...THAT'S
PHYSICALLY
POSSIBLE

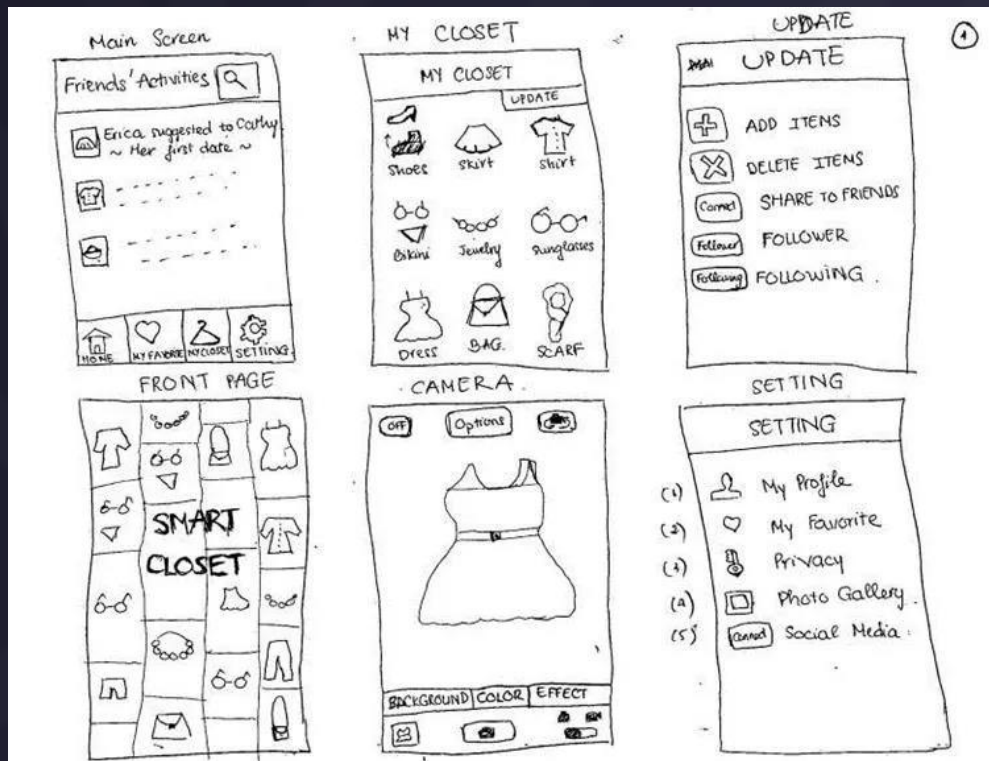


...ACTUALLY
HAPPENS



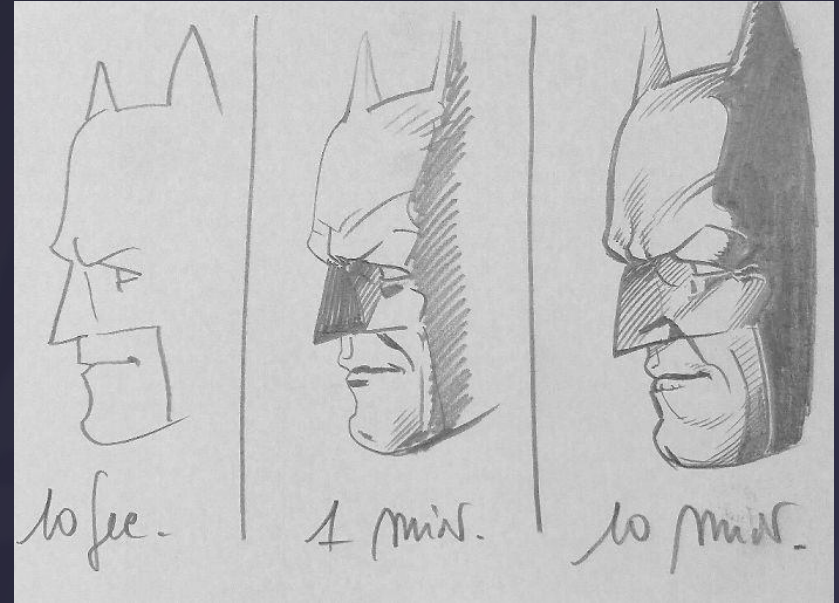
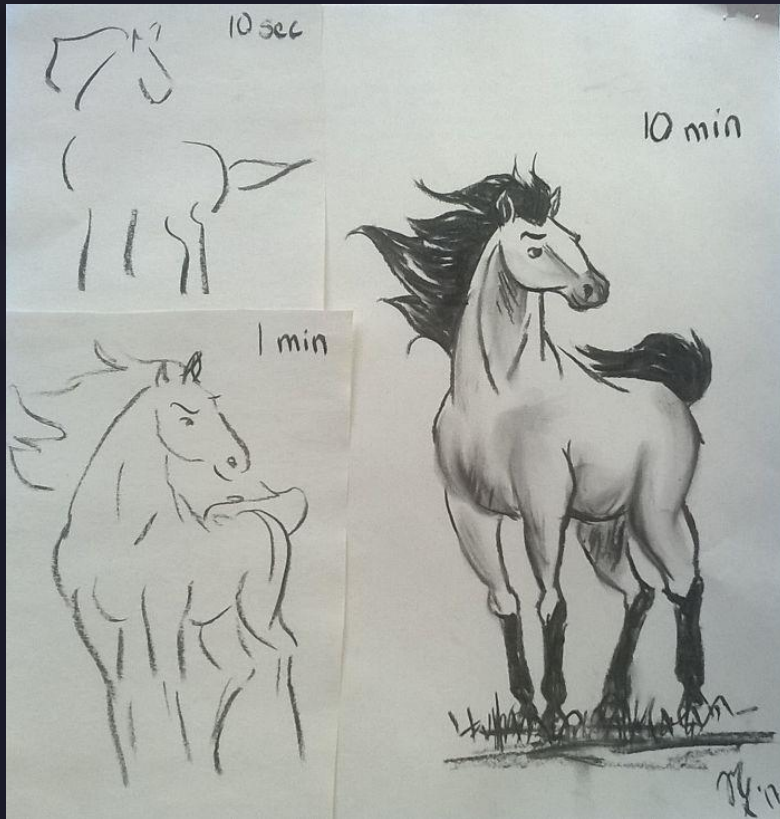
ERRANTSCIENCE.COM

Low Fidelity Prototyping



Roughly **80%** of your results come
from just **20%** of your efforts.

Pareto Principle



Speed Drawing Challenge Asks Artists To Sketch In 10 Mins, 1 Min, And 10 Secs
BoredPanda.com

Your MVP is the MVP

- **Minimum** Viable Product
 - Trying to put in All The Coolest Features is a waste of time and money if they don't add value for the buyer.
- Don't cram everything into your initial prototypes
 - Test the critical few and add things in as time/money/need allow.
 - You get clearer information with fewer variables.
 - Remember that this is an iterative process!

Talking With People: Challenge Your Assumptions

CUSTOMER INSIGHTS

Understanding Your Buyer



Listen to Your Interviewees!



why are women lying about this? like what's the actual cause?



Follow

In the first reply to this poll there is a picture of Olly Murs before and after a 12 week gym transformation.

Do you think he looks better before or after?

Are you male or female?



1920 votes • Final results



“Occasionally he stumbled over the truth, but he always picked himself up and hurried on as if nothing had happened”.

- Winston Churchill

1:35 PM · Apr 26, 2025 · **88.5M** Views

Users Aren't Always Buyers

- Who is using the product is not necessarily the one making the purchase decision; must address the **buyer's** problems to make sales.
 - Who buys men's underwear? 53.5% of men in relationships and 72.8% of single men.
- Users impact design choices and champion product to buyers
 - Ask for intros to the people making the money decisions

Ask Broad Questions

- What are their biggest problems or concerns? What keeps them up at night?
 - Don't limit this to just your focus area.
- How are they addressing the issues today? What is working and what is not?
 - "Doing nothing" is almost always an option
 - What would be a "perfect" solution?
- How is success measured?

Ask for money, get advice.
Ask for advice, get money twice.

Pitbull

Schedule Follow-Ups

- Go back to friendly interviewees later for a more detailed conversation around prototypes or features.
 - Give them options – “would you buy this?” is different from “how do we solve your problem?” and “what features are most appealing?”
 - What works? What doesn’t? What suggestions do they have?
 - You can ask high-level pricing questions here – would they pay \$ vs \$\$?
 - Would they **buy** this?
 - Would they recommend this to a colleague?

A costly experience.

Focus Areas: Dig Deeper

Key Performance Indicators & Metrics

What **buyer KPI** does your product address? How can you **measure** that quantitatively?

The Basics



- Businesses typically have some sort of quantitative metric that track whether the company and its employees are meeting their goals.
- How can you connect your solution to something your customer cares about? How can you measure that impact?

Possible Resources

- Direct interviews, either customer or manager
- Published papers and workforce surveys
- Regulatory or accreditation bodies
- Public progress reports for similar projects
- Keywords: KPIs, measures of success, quality indicators, metrics, assessments, benchmarks + your industry/buyer/problem

Behavioral Health KPIs

Key Performance Indicators (KPIs)

Measure	Directionality	FY 2019 Actual	FY 2020 Actual	FY 2021 Actual	FY 2022 Target
1 - Transform the District's behavioral health system into a nationally recognized, results-based model of care by promoting a common vision, accountable collective action, transparency, and innovative programs. (1 Measure)					
Percent of individuals referred through the emergency department medication assisted treatment programs who went to treatment.	Up is Better	New in 2021	New in 2021	49.3%	50%
2 - Ensure Individuals served at Saint Elizabeth's Hospital receive quality services to meet their unique needs. (4 Measures)					
Percent of unique patients restrained at least once.	Neutral	New in 2021	New in 2021	4.7%	8.4%
Percent of unique patients secluded at least once	Down is Better	New in 2021	New in 2021	2.7%	4.4%
Percent of patients satisfied with Facility/Environment	Up is Better	New in 2021	New in 2021	100.8%	80%
Percent of individuals from Saint Elizabeths Hospital readmitted within 90 days	Down is Better	New in 2020	0.9%	0.3%	2%
3 - Ensure Individuals and families receive quality services to meet their unique needs, resulting in access to the right services, at the right time, in the right amount. (7 Measures)					
Percent of consumers/clients satisfied with Access	Up is Better	New in 2021	New in 2021	78.9%	80%
Percent of Substance Use Disorder (SUD) clients who were successfully discharged that re-entered services within 90 days	Down is Better	New in 2021	New in 2021	17.1%	25%

Tutoring KPI Example

Key Performance Indicators: Tutoring Programs

Program Goals

- Increased student achievement and growth in elementary, middle, and high
- Close the learning gaps created by COVID closures

Outcomes

During School Tutoring

- Elementary and middle students in the bottom 15% who meet tutoring participation criteria will show an increase by 5 percentage points on pre- & post-assessments

Before- & After-School Tutoring

- Students in the bottom 20% who have a 95% participation rate will show a 5% increase on pre- & post-assessment results using the iReady diagnostic, EOC, and ACT tests
- Students with a 95% participation rate will show a 5% increase on pre- & post-assessment results using the iReady diagnostic, EOC and ACT tests.



+ something like PHQ-9?

Caregiver Survey Example

Zarit Caregiver Burden Assessment (Short, 12-items)

Name: _____

Date: _____

The following is a list of statements that reflect how people sometimes feel when taking care of another person. After reading each statement, indicate how often you experience the feelings listed by circling the number that best corresponds to the frequency of these feelings.

	Never	Rarely	Sometimes	Frequently	Nearly Always
1) Do you feel you don't have enough time for yourself?	0	1	2	3	4
2) Do you feel stressed between caring and meeting other responsibilities?	0	1	2	3	4
3) Do you feel angry when you are around your relative?	0	1	2	3	4
4) Do you feel your relative affects your relationship with others in a negative way?	0	1	2	3	4
5) Do you feel strained when are around your relative?	0	1	2	3	4
6) Do you feel your health has suffered because of your involvement with your relative?	0	1	2	3	4
7) Do you feel you don't have as much privacy as you would like, because of your relative?	0	1	2	3	4

+ something like PHQ-9?

How to Use Them

- Identify which KPIs are relevant and addressable
- Align data collection techniques with customers to “speak their language”
- Look for places to measure outcomes in the context of relevant KPIs. Pilots? Demos?
- Roll these into your grant applications, pitch decks, etc.

Acknowledging the Cost of Change

Determine the Whole Picture

- What steps in your customer's workflow must change to implement your solution?
 - Use generic workflow diagrams and interviews to dig in
- Do they even **want** to change? **Can** they change?
 - Are there systems they're stuck with?
- How painful are those changes?
 - "T-shirt sizing" here: small, medium, large
 - Can you reduce or eliminate the pain points?
- Consider physical, mental, financial, other impacts?

Examples

- Adding parts to inventory & maintenance, supplier qual.
- Workflow changes – who acts or how the work is done
- User training – initial and ongoing
- Space requirements and locations
- More logins & passwords
- Reporting or regulatory requirements
- Yet. Another. App.

COST OF CHANGE

"Cost of Adoption" = \$500



- Time, Effort, & Money Spent:
 - Breed registration & microchip
 - Quality food & supplements
 - Equipment
 - Vet care
 - Training classes
 - Potty training
 - Health testing
 - ***Socialization***

Women							
People of many ethnicities							
Tall men							
Men with deep voices							
Men with beards							
Elderly							
People wearing hats, helmets							
People wearing Ugg® boots							
People wearing hoodies							
People wearing backpacks							
People wearing sunglasses							
People with canes, walking sticks or walkers							
Teenagers							
Children standing as well as playing							
Toddlers (walking and squealing)							
Infants (crawling)							
People running by							
Indigent or homeless people							

COST OF CHANGE

Result = Priceless?



Bonus Points

Additional Interview Materials

Customer Journeys



- “A day in the life of...” visual guide that can help uncover hidden pressure points
 - Create a step-by-step workflow around the problem, either from personal insights or previous interviews.
 - Ask future interviewees if this matches their experiences; if not, what’s different? What causes the most friction?
 - Review the responses and look for areas that are similar or different across your interviewees. How can they shape your product?



Frequency-Frustration Matrix



- Define low, medium, and high rates for both problem occurrence (frequency) and impact (frustration)

- Frequency examples:

- Daily, monthly, annually
- Never, sometimes, always

- Frustration examples:

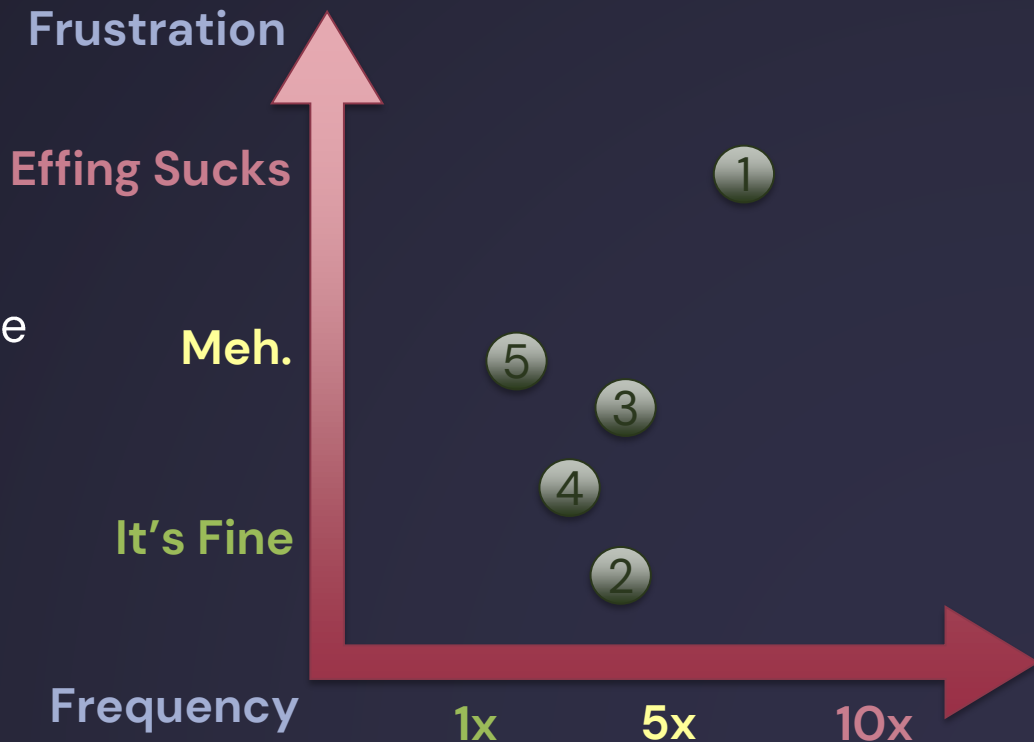
- \$100, \$1,000, \$100,000 additional costs
- 1 hour, 1 day, 1 month delays

▼ House		
☐	Task	Effort
☐	> Film house windows 4	Meh
☐	> Install ERV/HRV - DeZiel 5	Effing Sucks
☐	Stair treads	Meh
☐	Air purifier filters	Just Do It Already
☐	Hire organizer	Just Do It Already
☐	Design closet organizer	Meh
☐	Organize office	Meh

- Ask your interviewee where they'd place each problem

Frequency-Frustration Matrix

- Elements identified:
 1. Dealing with phone calls
 2. Waiting for answers
 3. Messaging the doctor's office
 4. Requesting refills online
 5. Picking up meds
- Frequency: 1x, 5x, 10x
- Frustration: It's Fine, Meh., Effing Sucks



Competitive Analysis: Who Else is Out There?

Why Do We Care?

Identifying who and what else is out there helps you understand where you and your product fit

Allows you to identify areas of differentiation that may be important to buyers

Investors, strategics, and other subject matter experts will know the market options

The Basics 1

- Find possible competitors
 - Web searches
 - Conference agendas & attendee lists
 - Personal connections
 - Industry newsletters & databases
 - Pitch competition presenter lists
 - Public investor portfolios
 - This also gives you information on who is investing in your space – future targets?

Current Companies

Actively backed ventures supported by Golden Seeds' national network of investors.

Showing 20 of 64 companies

Sectors	Status	Filter	Clear
All Sectors	All Status		

 Alcatraz AI ENTERPRISE (202) Alcatraz AI is transforming access control by leveraging AI where your face becomes your credential.	 AnaOno CONSUMER (202) AnaOno, tooth-inclusive linguals for those with chest differences.	 Avisi Technologies HEALTH CARE Developing a nanotechnology-enabled glaucoma device designed to lower intraocular pressure in patients with open-angle glaucoma.	 Bairitone Health HEALTH CARE Bairitone's sonar-powered wearable captures sleep apnea anatomy at home.
 Bone Health Technologies HEALTH CARE Bone Health Technologies is the maker of Osteobond, a safe and effective treatment for Osteoporosis.	 Breinify ENTERPRISE (202) Breinify's mission is to democratize data science with their proprietary & powerful predictive personalization platform.	 Cadenza Innovation ENTERPRISE (202) Licensing low-cost, high-capacity, safe Li-ion platform to TV and grid markets.	 Chromatic 3D Materials ENTERPRISE (202) Chromatic 3D is focused on the flexible, cost-effective and sustainable manufacturing of industrial-strength elastomeric products.
 Chromis Technologies ENTERPRISE (202) At Chromis, we don't just make specialty chemicals; we enable innovation across a broad spectrum of industries.	 CNote ENTERPRISE (202) CNote technology has unlocked a proven asset class previously only available to large banks to deliver the next generation of competitive cash and fixed income products.	 Concerto Biosciences HEALTH CARE We measure, map, and harness the microbial world to create best-in-class products.	 Cooler Heads HEALTH CARE First FDA-cleared portable scalp cooling medical device to reduce chemotherapy-induced hair loss.

The Basics 2

- Create a database and identify critical components to evaluate
 - Record company name, product name, and image or description
 - List ~5 critical components for review
 - What will your buyer consider when making a purchase?
 - Need to separate technologies but not overwhelm yourself
 - Consider availability of information
 - Don't forget about products or technologies that are close enough to be a threat in the future

The Basics 3

- Create a standardized assessment matrix
 - Include each of your critical components, weighting them if necessary
 - Identify scoring criteria using “T-shirt sizing”
 - Ideal, acceptable, unacceptable
 - Time to result: <5 minutes, 5–15 minutes, >15 minutes
 - Size: smartphone, toaster, minifridge
- Grade each competitor and review results
 - May need to add, remove, or adjust criteria

The Basics 4



- Your competitive analysis is a **living document**.
 - Update when new information, priorities, or competitors show up
- Use the information to clarify your differentiation.
- Same as the rest? Figure out what needs to change.
- Prove why you're better.
 - Pitch decks, grant applications, customer materials, etc.

Not Just for Business

Year	Make	Model	Trim	HP	Torque	Price	MPG	Inventory	\$/HP	Score	Bonus	Weighted
2020/2021	Toyota	Camry	XLE V6	301	267	34995	22/33	38454	128	33	1.5	50
2020/2021	Toyota	Camry	TRD	301	267	32185	22/31	32384	108	31	1.5	47
2021	Toyota	Supra	3.0 Premium	382	368	55485	22/30	56680	147	29	1.5	44
2020	Toyota	Supra		335	365	49990	24/31	57440	171	29	1.5	44
2021	Hyundai	Sonata	N Line	290	311	34195	26/35	34195	118	41	0	41
2020/2021	Honda	Accord	Limited	252	273	36700	22/32	37095	147	27	1.5	41
2020/2021	Mazda	6	Grand Touring	250	310	31740	23/31	31565	126	37	0	37
2020/2021	Toyota	Avalon	Limited	301	267	42175	22/31	45044	150	23	1.5	35
2020/2021	Toyota	Avalon	TRD	301	267	42875	21/30	45249	150	23	1.5	35
2020/2021	Kia	Stinger	GT1	365	376	45490	17/25	47175	129	31	0	31
2020/2021	Tesla	Model 3	Long Range	346	376	48990	N/A	55020	159	31	0	31
2020/2021	Ford	Mustang	Ecoboost Premium	310	350	40210	21/31	44860	145	31	0	31
2020/2021	Ford	Mustang	GT Premium	460	420	46770	16/25	53495	116	29	0	29
2020/2021	Genesis	G70	3.3T Prestige	365	376	44650	17/25	50320	138	29	0	29
2021	Chevrolet	Corvette	1LT	490	470	66175	15/27	72305	148	27	0	27
2021	Toyota	Supra	2.0	255	295	42990	22/30	47470	186	17	1.5	26
2020	Toyota	86	Auto	200	151	27060	21/28	31074	155	17	1.5	26
2020/2021	Kia	Stinger	GT-Line	255	260	33090	22/29	37180	146	23	0	23
2020	Mazda	Miata	RF Club	181	151	35185	26/35	35250	195	21	0	21
2020/2021	Hyundai	Sonata	Limited	180	195	33850	27/37	34830	194	21	0	21
2020/2021	Genesis	G70	2.0T Elite	252	260	35450	20/27	41420	164	17	0	17

COMPETITIVE ANALYSIS

Outcome?



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Let's *Connect*

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